



Off to Grandmother's House

Little Red stood outside of the small log cabin that she shared with her mother and stepfather. It was the coldest part of Winter and everything around her was covered in untouched snow.

Inside the cabin, her mother had just finished preparing two jars of food and a loaf of bread which she had placed inside of a basket. In a moment, she would open the door to the cabin and give this basket to Little Red so that she could deliver it to her grandmother who lived in another part of the woods.

It was a long walk to grandmother's house. It would take Little Red most of the afternoon and evening to travel there and back home again. It was about noon and the sun didn't stay out long at this time of year.

A moment later, the only entrance to the cabin behind her finally opened and her mother yelled for her to come take the basket.

Little Red turned around and ran back to where her mother stood, holding the door open. Her mother extended the basket towards Little Red and she reached out with her right arm to grab it out of her mother's hand. It was heavier than it had looked to her.

"Now, remember what I told you about walking through the woods alone, don't you?" her mother asked her with a serious look of concern.

Little Red nodded, trying not to roll her eyes at the question she'd been asked at least three times this morning.

Although her mother saw the nod, she pretended as if she hadn't and a moment later snapped:

"I said what did I tell you about walking through the woods alone, miss?"

Little Red sighed and felt the basket get heavier with the sarcasm of youth.

"I'm not to take so much as one step off the path and I must go directly to grandmother's house and straight back home again," she recited to appease her mother.

Her mother looked down at her and frowned.

"Do we remember why?" she asked.

Before waiting for a response from Little Red, she immediately followed it up with:

"There are dangerous and evil creatures deep in the forest. You must never speak to any of them, they can't be trusted."

Little Red nodded several times in acknowledgement. With one hand on her hip, the mother nodded back and motioned forward with her head to send Little Red on her way to grandmother's house.

Not taking anything her mother says too seriously, Little Red starts down the path through the woods to her grandmother's with the basket on one arm and a devious expression on her face.

As she begins the walk through the woods, she travels the clearly defined path through the snow that leads to her grandmother's. She thinks of all the boys she goes to school with in

her village. She's just reached the age when they start asking the girls out on dates and a couple of the boys that lived nearby had asked her, but she had laughed at them.

Thinking back on their clumsy advances made her giggle aloud even now. They were so silly to her, she couldn't take them seriously if she tried. She wonders when she will find a boy who deserves her.

Not too far off into the distance, a wolf is lurking somewhere off the path that Little Red travels, deeper in the woods than she is supposed to go. He hears the faint sound of a young girl laughing not too far from where he stands, one paw in mid-air as his ear twitches at the sound it hears.

He pauses in mid-step and listens. After a moment, he begins to move towards the girl's voice.

A Stranger in the Woods

By this time, Little Red has made quite some progress and is about half way to grandmother's. The basket is growing heavy on her arm so she shifts it from one to the other to give the first one a break.

Out of nowhere, she hears a young man yell out to her:

"That looks heavy, my dear!"

She stops dead in her tracks, eyes wide and glances to her side as the man approaches her with his hand extended. Soon he is standing right next to her, though he remains off the path and in the snow.

"Please, allow me to carry your basket for you. It looks dreadfully heavy and you look as if you've been walking for a good distance."

Little Red looks at him for a moment, thinking of what has just happened. He is attractive and looks like he couldn't be any older than 20 or so. His hair is a brownish color and it's just a little disheveled. He's wearing a brown button-up sweater and gray pants.

One of his hands is reaching out for the basket and the other remains in the pocket of his pants, very casually. One of his hands is reaching out for the basket and the other remains

in the pocket of his pants, very casually.

She looks up and they make eye contact. His eyes are piercingly green and mesmerizing. They make her gasp slightly.

She clears her throat finally, ending the long silence.

Without saying anything, she holds the basket out towards him and he slips his arm under it and lets it hang there. He smiles warmly, asking her:

"Where are you headed, love?"

"I...to my...I'm going to my grandmother's," replies Little Red, feeling very unsure of herself.

"Ah, very well then. I'd love to carry this basket for you until I have to go in a different direction, so let's be on our way my dear."

With that said, he motions in front of them as if telling her to lead the way. Little Red nods after a moment and begins to walk further towards her grandmother's house.

As they cover more distance, he remains walking in the snow beside her while she doesn't leave the path through the snow.

Behind him he leaves a trail of paw prints in the snow, though Little Red doesn't come close to noticing this as she's too busy being charmed by him as they get to know one another on their journey.

"What on Earth are your mother and father thinking sending you alone out into the woods, I must know?" Don't they know how dangerous it is for a beautiful young girl to be out here?"

"Yes, of course they do," replies Little Red. *"I'm not supposed to stray from the path and I must go straight home after I deliver the basket to my grandmother."*

He laughs, throwing his head back in the air, revealing a set of teeth that look just a little too sharp and pointed, though he's too tall for Little Red to catch a good glimpse of them.

"Goodness, they should still be worried. I wouldn't send you out here if it was me. You're

far too precious."

This made Little Red blush and look down at her feet as she walked.

Was this man flirting with her? Surely he was too old, but she did find him terribly attractive. He looked like one of her people, someone who could easily have lived in her village though she had never seen him anywhere before today.

"Well Little Red, why don't I watch out for you while we're together?" he asked her, looking down at her as they walked.

"What do you say? I won't let any harm come to you and perhaps when you return home, I'll ask your parents if I can have you all to myself?"

Little Red looks up at him, surprised.

"Whatever do you mean, all to yourself?"

He shrugs and looks down before saying:

"I don't know...I am only playing with you, let's move faster. The sun is down now and it's getting darker and colder by the minute. You'll freeze if we don't hurry."

A Fork in the Path

Soon the two of them come to a fork in the path. To the right, grandmother's house lies not far ahead.

"Well, Little Red...it looks like our journey ends here. I must go this direction to get where I am going," he says while he motions to the leftward path."

"Will you be all right without me the rest of the way?" he asks her, with a genuinely concerned expression on his face.

She doesn't want him to leave. They have already become fast friends in the time they have spent together walking and she wishes he would wait for her and walk all the way back home with her after she drops off the basket at her grandmother's.

She sighs and looks down, not saying anything for a moment. She feels some tears start to well up in her eyes and tries as best she can to fight them back, not wanting him to see how affected she is by him after such a short time.

"Yes," she says, though she struggles to get the word out clearly without her voice being broken by the dam that holds back her childish tears.

She coughs to hide the emotion and then regains her composure.

"It's not much further at all, I will be fine," she manages to add with her head raised up again now.

He can smell her tears and feel everything she is thinking. She is no match for him. She is young and doesn't know how to hide these things, she might as well be wearing the words that describe her juvenile feelings as he looked at her with a hint of longing and lust.

"Very well then, my dear. Do be careful. I hope we meet again someday." he says to her.

"Do you think we will?" Little Red asks almost as soon as he finishes his last word.

The hope in her voice bouncing off of the end of his sentence and hitting her like a boomerang thrown between the two figures standing there in the snowy woods.

Sensing the desperation in her own voice, she quickly adds:

"It's just that we are already such good friends, don't you think?"

With a slightly sinister grin, he replies:

"Why yes...yes, I'd say so."

"We'll meet again Little Red, don't you worry about that."

Just in Time for Tea

The next moment, she is standing alone there in the woods. Was any of it real? Where did he disappear to so fast? She looks around her once and then with a heavy heart, continues on towards her grandmother's. She is nearly there.

A few moments later, she finally sees her grandmother's log cabin in the distance. She switches the basket from one arm to another for the final stretch of the journey.

Taking a deep breath, she carries on towards the cabin and soon she finds herself at the door. She wishes that he was still with her and she realizes that she forgot to ask for his name.

She was in love with a boy for the first time and she didn't even know what to call him. This seemed wrong to her and she wondered if it was really accurate to think of him as a boy, or if he was in fact a man.

She wasn't sure, it seemed like he was right on the cusp between the two things. They seemed vastly different to her and it distressed her somewhat that she couldn't be sure of which he actually was.

She knocks on the door and her grandmother opens it, welcoming her and inviting her in.

"You've finally made it here!" she exclaims.

She puts her hand on Little Red's shoulder and pulls her into the warm cabin with all the maternal decorations that she was used to seeing in both her mother and grandmother's homes.

"I was just getting ready to have my tea, dear. You must stay and have some with me. Sit down, sit down! You've walked so far, you need to give your feet some rest."

Little Red sat down at the small wooden table there in her grandmother's kitchen. She could hardly pay attention to what her grandmother was saying as she asked her all the normal questions about her health and school and everything else she always asked about.

Her mind was elsewhere. It was with the young man she had parted ways with only a short while before.

She couldn't stop thinking about him and struggling to remember exactly how he looked and the new, exciting range of things it had made her feel to look at him and listen to him speak as they had walked together.

The grandmother pours her some tea and adds a spoonful of sugar, then two spoonfuls of

honey and Little Red begins to stir them into the hot cup of tea in front of her.

She's staring off into the distance, trying to rewind her memory when her grandmother suddenly yells out:

"Sonny, could you please tend to the fire? It is threatening to go out and we can't have that!"

Little Red frowns, puzzled by the question and immediately intrigued about who it was directed at. A moment later, she hears a familiar voice reply:

"Of course, Ma'am. I'll be right there, you hang tight for just a moment."

Her grandmother looks at her and smiles.

"He's such a lovely man, he really is."

"Who's that," asks Little Red, not yet placing the voice she had heard so recently.

"This lovely man from the village, he helps me carry my groceries from the marketplace here to the cabin and makes sure I have logs to feed the fire with. He's out back cutting me some now, so hopefully the fire stays alive or we'll both freeze!"

As Little Red raises her cup of tea to take the first drink, the man enters the room and her eyes grow wider than the saucer her cup sat atop a moment before.

Overcome with disbelief, she drops the tea cup in perfect timing with a sudden sob of shock that she lets out before she has a chance to keep it to herself, sending it to the ground where it crashes into four or five jagged fragments that each go flying in their own direction.

Secrets With Strangers

It was him. The man who carried her basket for most of the journey through the woods. She can't believe it.

He's wearing different clothes now. Instead of the sweater from earlier, he is wearing a heavy coat that's lined in fur. His pants are black now and appear to be made of a rougher

material than the gray ones he was wearing when they had crossed paths.

How could this possibly be? It was definitely him, she was sure of it. There was no denying that. But how did he beat her here? Where did he come from? Who was he, after all?

Her grandmother scolded her for dropping the tea cup and went to clean up the mess it had made. Little Red couldn't take her eyes off of the man, she was fixated on him the entire time, almost in a trance.

His eyes were locked on her as well. From one corner of his mouth, a playful smirk stretched across half of his face and he winked right at her.

Little Red gulped immediately, clueless as to how she should react or respond to his presence.

There was no way she could admit to her grandmother that she knew him. A moment ago, she had heard her refer to him as a man, not a boy. Admittedly, he did look far more like one now than he had what seemed like only moments before this when they were still alone together in the woods.

She knew she wasn't supposed to know any men besides her father and her teachers. There would be no good excuse for having been alone with him in the woods on their way there, she knew that much. It must remain a secret, she concluded to herself.

It was their secret. The two of them knew and neither of them could speak a word about it in her grandmother's presence. There was an unspoken mutual understanding between them and they could both sense it inexplicably.

While Little Red was struggling not to give away the secret with her staring and awkwardness, the man seemed to find it incredibly easy to act as if he'd never seen her before this moment.

It was obvious that her grandmother had no idea he'd accompanied her on her way there, as he gave no signs to let on to this at all.

He moved around smoothly, looked innocent when speaking to her grandmother and hardly took notice of Little Red. The flirtatious energy that he had focused on her during the walk was no longer present, it had dried up like a Winter well.

Little Red, on the other hand, was not hiding her own feelings too well and finally her grandmother asked her:

"My goodness, child, what is wrong with you? You've hardly spoken a word since you arrived and you're acting as if someone has put a spell on you!"

Shaking her head slightly to bring herself back to reality, Little Red responded:

"Oh, I...I'm fine. Just tired from the walk is all."

Her grandmother frowned and shook her head, dismissing the young girl for now and began to thank the man for his help.

As she sat there watching the two of them interact, she wondered to herself how it could be that he was suddenly someone else entirely when they both knew otherwise. Why did he act as if he didn't know her and how could he so easily slip between one identity and another she had never seen before?

While she wasn't sure about the answers to those questions, she still had a very basic instinctual sense of the wrongness of their first meeting in the woods. She wished that her grandmother was gone and that she could speak to him the way she had earlier.

The first thing she would ask him was his name.

Putting Grandmother to Sleep

Right before he is about to exit the cabin, he looks at Little Red with a question in his eyes and she immediately knows he is asking for her permission to rid them of her grandmother's presence.

She closes her mouth and purses her lips slightly, her eyes narrowing just the tiniest bit before she gives him a single nod of her head to affirm her feelings.

His smile now takes on the same devilish appearance that it had in the woods earlier, and he grabs the grandmother by the neck and places his hand over her eyes so that Little Red can't see her face.

The old woman stiffens rather quickly, struggling against his huge hand for only a moment

or two before her body goes limp.

He closes her eyes with his hand before removing it from her face and then carries her body over to the bed and places her in it, covering her body with the blanket before he returns to kneel down in front of Little Red as she sits there at the table waiting for him.

He takes Little Red's hand in both of his, looking up at her and straight into her eyes as deeply as anyone has ever looked into them before. His stare is so intense that she feels as if it has removed all of her clothes, her skin, her everything.

He waits for her to speak with a smile on his face.

"Is she...?" she begins to ask, turning her head slightly towards where her grandmother lay on the bed.

He nods, still smiling and says:

"She is only sleeping, Little Red. She's an old woman, after all. She's tired. We have done her no harm, worry not."

His words make Little Red feel much better and she almost immediately forgets about her grandmother altogether. Without pausing too long, she asks him:

"What is your name?"

As he answers, she swears that the green of his eyes changes several shades until it appears to be an unnatural Chartreuse that seers through her soul.

"Wolfgang, my dear."

She smiles, thinking it's a fine name. It feels much better knowing the name of the man she is in love with. After all, he's the first. She remembers how wrong everyone will think it is that she has fallen in love with a man who was far too old for her.

Frowning, she asks him:

"But what will everyone say when I tell them? Surely they won't approve of us," she added.

"Not to worry," he replied.

"Come now, we'll go face them all together. How can they not approve of us if we are in love, Little Red?" he asks, his smile cunning and almost perverse.

Unsure of what he means and not convinced that they will accept the two of them as they are, she lets him pull her by the hand ever so gently, so that she is standing up and facing him now.

He leans down to her, still holding her hand in his, and kisses her lips. Everything that has stood between them until this moment is shattered into oblivion as Little Red can feel herself come alive at his touch. Suddenly she feels things she had never known, the cold of Winter outside melted from the great heat within her.

The chemistry between them infused her and they kissed again, longer this time. Soon his hand wandered to her bosom, where it cleverly unfastened her slip and he reached into it to feel her bare skin.

She was his now. She wanted him the way he had wanted her since he first laid eyes on her in the forest earlier that day.

Leaving The Cabin

Breathing heavily as if she had just ran through the woods the entire way from her cabin,

Little Red asks him:

"What shall we do now?"

"Let's go meet them. I'll tell them everything and we can leave this place if they don't approve. We can be together like this forever."

She nods, smiling wide and excitedly. She fastens her slip and smooths her red cape, pulling the hood back over her dark long hair. When all signs of their passion a moment ago have been hidden, she takes a deep breath and gives him an expression of readiness.

He walks to the door of the cabin, opening it all the way to reveal the dark, snowy woods in the near distance. Still smiling, she begins to walk towards the door, giving him a sidelong glance of playful lust that wouldn't have been possible during their walk through the

woods.

He watches her as she exits the cabin and when she is standing out there in the snow, he pulls the door shut behind him and joins her.

Something has changed about Little Red. The difference in height between her and the young man had become less. She seemed now only a head shorter than him.

She looked down at her hands and was surprised to find them much larger than they had been before she walked out of the cabin. Her fingers were longer, more pointed. Feminine but not a girl's hands any more.

Her hair was even longer than it had been just moments before. It had a waviness she didn't recognize as well. As the young man looked at her, he saw that her bosom was now struggling to remain covered by the slip she wore. Her face took on a wholly different appearance now.

At the corners of her eyes, there were the slightest creases when she smiled. They made her look even more irresistible and there was a lustiness about her that she lacked earlier.

She went to speak and was startled by the slightly deeper and more mature tone of her voice as she asked him:

"Where should we go now?"

He smiled, looking at her as if she was something he was hunting in the woods.

"Where do you want to go?" he asked her.

"Should we still return home to tell mother and father that we're leaving?" she asked, marvelling at the physical changes that had taken place.

"It hardly seems necessary, Little Red. I don't think there is any need to go back there now," he answered.

"I suppose you're right," she said as she looked up at the sky above her.

It was filled with stars and possibilities. She was ready to go new places and do things she hadn't even yet imagined.

He moved towards her and the two of them joined hands. They looked at one another for a moment, then started back towards the woods together, two adult sized figures standing against the dark of the night as the snow fell around them.

Behind them, the young man left a trail of paw prints in the snow. Little Red's footprints were larger than they would have been as she made her way through the woods earlier. They were also tinged with blood the same color as her red cape and hood.